‘India would develop an active concern in world affairs, pursuing an independent policy compatible with her own national interests – a statement of objective which remained true throughout his years in office’. However, according to Gopal ‘at the start there was little precision and definiteness about this objective. It appeared to consist primarily of vague and rather grandiose hopes of closer ties between Asian countries and even the formation of two or three Asian federations.’ In Gopal’s words ‘the foreign policy of a newly independent nation does not emerge overnight’ and ‘with the general directions clear in his mind, Nehru set about building up the foreign policy of India brick by brick, in the process discarding the generalizations which had taken the place of rigorous thought’. [14]

Echoing the views expressed by many of his colleagues and the feelings of fellow Indians, Nehru assumed that India was destined to play a major role in the globe because of its rich history, tradition, resources, location and population. In a speech in March 1949 Nehru stated: ‘Remember that India, not because of any ambition of hers, but because of the force of circumstances, because of geography, because of history and because of so many other things, inevitably has to play a very important part in Asia.’[15] There was an inevitability to India’s greatness, in his mind. ‘India need only wait until others understand and accommodate to the Indian position,’ he once declared. Nehruvianism implies waiting for the ‘inevitable consequence of what India is and what a free India must be’[16] instead of scrambling to seek alliances or take advantage of global conflicts and crises.

Tied to the notion of India’s inevitable rise was the view that India had a moral obligation to use her influence for good in the world. On the one hand, the claim to higher moral ground had an emotional appeal and connected India – and Nehru – to the father of the nation, Mahatma Gandhi, who had emphasized ethics in pursuit of politics. At another level, there was a realist rationale for painting India as a preachy, altruistic global actor.